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Isolated-Collective Intent:
In Goncharov (1973) and Classic Literature

The attempt to assign a degree of importance to the intentions of artists in interpreting a piece of art has led to a spectrum of responses, from intentionalists, who believe that only authorial intention matters, to anti-intentionalists, who seek to interpret a work only as a work without any ties to its author. However, I believe that there exist some instances of narrative artworks that cannot be interpreted by any practices proposed by current theories regarding authorial intent – works with multiple authors working separately to create one single text.

These works are made with what I call 'isolated-collective intent'. In this paper, I will argue that it is not possible to satisfactorily account for interpretation of works with isolated-collective intent under the current philosophical frameworks of intentionalism, particularly focusing on those put forth by Levinson and Carroll.

Intentionalism, Explained

Between the intentionalist and anti-intentionalist extremes, several theorists have taken a more balanced position between these two theories. This is because both these extremes seem to be lacking, and the failure of these two stances resulted in theories which slightly revised them in order to circumvent the problems they faced. I will discuss these problems and the dominant

alternatives to them: Carroll's modest actual intentionalism and Levinson's hypothetical intentionalism.

It is difficult to adhere to extreme intentionalism because it needs us to eschew our shared conventions of language in favour of meaning arbitrarily chosen by the author; for example, under extreme intentionalism, an author can claim that they intended to use the word 'bow' in order to mean something entirely irrelevant like 'blanket', and this would be the correct interpretation. On the other hand, anti-intentionalism is difficult for philosophers to accept because it puts too much emphasis on reader response. That is, the meaning construed by the reader (based on linguistic and literary conventions) is the correct interpretation. In this case, there is an almost-reversal of extreme intentionalism, where the readers choose the meaning of the text among multiple linguistically correct meanings; for example, whether 'bow' means a bow-tie, the act of taking a bow, or the bow of bow-and-arrow are entirely subjective.

The problem for anti-intentionalism is particularly problematic in cases of irony, where what the author says is actually the opposite of what they mean, such as in Figure 1 – in context, the headline is meant to be satirically criticizing Elon Musk, but an anti-intentionalist could not come to this conclusion simply by the words written here; they might even think this article lauds Musk.



Figure 1. Kronfeld, Damien. November 1 2022, Reductress.

One way to interpret a work of art without committing the mistake of accepting irony at face value is Levinson's hypothetical intentionalism. Under this framework, the right interpretation can be determined by the best hypothesis of an author's intent that readers can arrive at, given information about the author such as their education, their other works, biographical information and so forth. The hypothetical intentionalist could correctly determine that the Reductress headline above is satire, based on information such as the website's 'About Us' page. In essence, the hypothetical intentionalist contextualizes the text in order to interpret it.

If the author of the article, Damien Kronfeld, stated that his intention was to make Elon Musk's Twitter management look good, the hypothetical intentionalist would still not take this into consideration while interpreting the headline – it stops short of accepting authorial statements of intent, thus the best hypothesis is still that the headline is satire. What if perhaps we find out that Kronfeld and Musk are good childhood friends? Levinson says that in the case that there are two such best hypotheses supported by evidence, the meaning of the work is indeterminate between them.

On the other hand, Carroll's modest intentionalism would certainly consider that Kronfeld's intention was the correct interpretation. Provided that the text's use of language and literature supports the author's intention, this intention is taken to be the correct interpretation. Thus, Carroll denies any purported satire in Figure 1 provided that Kronfeld states his intentions were indeed to make Musk look good.

While both these theories make compelling points in our discussion of narrative interpretation, I believe that their claims to provide a framework for "Interpretation and Intention in Literature" (titles: Levinson; Carroll) falls short in the first place because it does not account for several instances of literary works – those with multiple authors who work separately.

Isolated-Collective Works, Posing Problems

In the case of Martin Scorsese's *Goncharov (1973)*, we have a wealth of interpretative material found in its convoluted plot line, loveable yet morally corrupt characters, self-reflexive narration bordering on satire on the production of mafia films, and an ambiguous ending. But Scorsese is not, in fact, the director of this film… because this film doesn't actually exist. In 2022, bloggers on the microblogging site Tumblr made up *Goncharov* as a joke from a picture of some off-brand shoes that misspelled the original name[1], which spawned people creating a poster, a soundtrack, a trailer and even a Google document script for the film.

The question of whether this 'film' is an artwork is certainly an interesting one, but immaterial to the present paper. Rather, what I am interested in with regards to the phenomenon of *Goncharov (1973) (2022)* is the process of its creation and its reception – something shockingly akin to oral folktales or mythological texts. In the case of *Goncharov*, the 'plot' was created across a series of distinct posts that did not reference each other; that is, the writer of one post did not know someone else was simultaneously writing another post about *Goncharov*. However, through cross-posting by other users, both the posts that describe a 'scene' of the movie written in isolation became not only fused, but unified: together, all these 'scenes' created the skeleton of the plot.

As one blogger points out: "whatever is written or made about goncharov is technically goncharov itself (sic)"[2]. It is important to note that people did layer different elements and different themes onto some already defined ones, but the point I narrow to is that there were

[1] The boots were probably a reference to the film was Gomorrah, directed by Matteo Garrone, according to this post.
[2] Tumblr post, November 21st 2022.

simultaneous and unique contributions that existed without any collaboration between users, and I call all works produced similarly as created with 'isolated-collective intent'.

This kind of intention cannot be handled by the above intentionalist theories described because these theories hinge on a single author and their intent. Though Levinson grants that there might be co-authored texts, it is with the constraint that they are all "working together" (footnote 7, Levinson 177). The collective intent of all authors working together produces the text; however, the case of 'isolated-collective intent' wherein the multiple authors are isolated from each other but contributing to the same text is entirely unconsidered by current theories of intentionalism.

Goncharov (1973) (2022) is a convenient way of tracking, through the ease of the internet, a much larger phenomenon pervasive in literature: the passing of folktales or myths in oral tradition across generations, with each new iteration changing meaning depending on the orator. In this tradition, the various 'authors' of the story are isolated from each other by either time or place, yet they collectively create a single text. I maintain that the only condition for isolated-collective intent works is that there is a coherent or consistent story at the end; any random sentences clubbed together as in games like Chinese Whispers are not works of isolated-collective intent.

In other words, a story is read out at t_1 by a person, who is heard by other people, and these other people separately retell this story at t_2,t_3,t_4 and so forth without knowledge that the other people are also doing so. The story told at t_x is coherent and similar (but not necessarily the same) as that told at t_1, but it can hardly be attributed to either the t_1 or the t_x author, precisely because the individual contributions of each author between t_1 and the t_x are also subsumed into the story.

For example, the Medieval English classic *Beowulf* has an unknown author, called the 'Beowulf poet' by critics; however, it is widely considered that they merely wrote down or compiled the oral story in *written* form (Frank), and cannot be considered the sole author of the work. The mythological text *Ramayana* has multiple different versions with differently named characters and locations, but the same story which is often studied as a singular text (Kumar). The Beowulf poet's intent is plainly isolated from his centuries-old predecessors, who in turn are among themselves isolated from each other, yet they collectively produced a text. The *Ramayana*'s orators are separated by geography and subsequently language, yet they collectively inform each other's stories such that they conclude in a coherent final text. These are both instances of isolated-collective intent.

Though in these two instances, the origin of the works are obscure, the problem of isolated-collective intent should not be explained away, as the modest intentionalist is wont to do, by simply saying that the intent or context of the original author, even if unknown to us, is the true intent or context. This is because it denies the evolution of the text we read currently – even if, at one point, the story was the product of one mind, the way we know it now is irrevocably changed by multiple minds since then. The story produced is an amalgamation of several authors isolated from each other, and it is not possible for us to ascribe any one part of the text to one author, irrespective of whether we are aware of each author's identity or not.

In isolated-collective intended texts, the question arises how we interpret these texts if their linguistic and literary conventions do not seem to support their interpretative meaning. Carroll's modest actual intentionalism fails us entirely in this regard due to multitude of intent from each author that it will accept but cannot rank or discriminate between, if there is a dispute among authors. Levinson's hypothetical intentionalism is perhaps in a marginally better position

to give us a way to answer: it can make an interpretation because we are allowed to have multiple best hypotheses that may equally take into account each author's context and meaning of the text becomes indeterminate between them; but yet, in practicality, hypothesising about which part of which author's oeuvre contributed a certain part of the text is intuitively unsatisfactory, not to mention the tiresome.

Thus, I believe that neither Carroll nor Levinson are fully equipped to interpret works of isolated-collective intent, precisely because the narrative fragments under this kind of scrutiny. However, there may still be some cases to be made for current philosophical frameworks to possibly refute against this theory, of which I have discussed the most serious below.

Objections

Anti-intentionalism can answer for isolated-collective intent works: Since anti-intentionalism only views the text without any reference to its author(s), it can easily deal with isolated-collective intent works by simply ignoring this intent. But, as mentioned earlier in the paper, anti-intentionalism poses significant problems for us in cases of satire (see Figure 1), where the text can be incorrectly interpreted. In fact, for works of isolated-collective intent, that evolve over time, it becomes even more important to be able to analyse them across different time periods because the story persisted in its retelling for a reason. Even if we take anti-intentionalism to mean that interpretation of a text in this mode means adhering to linguistic conventions 'at the time' of writing, we might still miss the presence of satire or political/cultural difference.

The intent was not to create a single text: If all these authors were indeed working in isolation, then surely their intent was never consciously to contribute to the t_x text. In other words, the

problem is that the authors were unaware they were contributing to a text at all, thus naturally their intent does not manifest in the t_x text. Though this may be true, the fact is that the text is reproduced and recreated in every iteration, and for all authors (except the t_1 author, who I will address later) they consciously chose to retell the story. That was their intent, even if the consequence that they contributed to a 'final' text was not. In any case, the final text is what we read and their contributions to it cannot be erased.

Different iterations are different works: It could also be possible to circumvent the isolated-collective intent problem by simply making each author distinct from each other, and each version of the story becomes a different text. There are two reasons why this solution is not useful. First, it presupposes that we have all the different iterations which, as *Beowulf* shows, we do not have for all instances of the genre. Second, even if we had different the iterations, it is plain to see that we cannot wholly attribute the story to a single author in good faith – we always go back to the problem of being unable to erase the layers of previous author's contributions, which persistently inform the text.

Narrow the field of theories: We can simply say that Carroll and Levinson deal with single author or co-authored works, where there is singular intent. This easily solves the problem I am posing, that these theories cannot account for isolated-collective intent. However, the new problem that then arises is how to interpret isolated-collective intent works at all – as we have already proven, anti-intentionalism does not provide a satisfactory answer either. Thus, the isolated-collective intent becomes a problem for the philosophy of art interpretation as a whole.

Working in isolation does not mean different intent: Collective intent is differentiated from isolated-collective intent on the constraint that the authors are not able to collaborate together, which in itself assumes that the authors have different intentions because they did not

communicate with each other. It could be possible that they have the same intent in recreating the story at each iteration, only unaware that other people had the same intent and this could then be a case of singular intent in isolated-collective intent works. However, though this certainly solves some of the problem, it does not address the rest of the concern – namely, that the authors are in different contexts, either in time or in location.

Author at t_1 considered the principal author: The author at t_1 is, of course, the exception to the problem of isolated-collective intent because they are the original author, and their intent for the story at t_1 is singular intent. However, only analysing this work does not solve the isolated-collective intent problem, because we do, in fact, analyse isolated-collective intent works as we saw with *Beowulf* and *Ramayana.* Neither can we ascribe the t_1 author the 'primary' or 'principal' author for the t_x text as we do when scientific papers have multiple authors, because we presume that there is singular collective intent and that the principal author is aware of the changes made by the secondary authors.

Conclusion

It is clear that works with multiple authors working separately from each other, isolated-collective intent works, pose a problem of interpretation under current frameworks of intentionalism and anti-intentionalism. These works have layers of intent that cannot be extricated from each other; at the same time, the intent cannot be entirely dismissed either. Thus, there is a need to address these instances of literary works in the philosophy of art interpretation.

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